JOHN AMPONG

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EDUCATIONAL BACKGROUND

University of South Carolina *2022–Present*
Ph.D. in Business Administration, Concentration in Finance

Xiamen University *2018–2020*
Master of Applied Economics in Financial Engineering

University of Cape Coast *2013–2017*
Bachelor of Management Studies (Hons.)

WORKING PAPERS

Changing the Subject: How Managerial Attention Reallocation Obscures Bad News (JMP)

- **Conferences and Seminars:** 3rd AI in Finance Conference (2026), Financial Management Association Consortium (2026), ABFR Doctoral Research Symposium (2026 scheduled), 3rd Annual Boca Finance and Real Estate Conference (2026 scheduled), Brown Bag Seminar, University of South Carolina (2026)

View abstract

Can a Shareholder Focus Create Value for All Stakeholders? (with Matthew Souther)

- **Media Coverage:** *The Columbia Law School Blue Sky Blog (June 10, 2025)*
- **Conferences and Seminars:** Georgia State – *Management Science* AI & FinTech Conference (2025), Financial Management Association (2025), Southern Finance Association (2025), RCF-ECGI Corporate Finance and Governance Conference (2026)
- **Awards:** *Best Paper Award (Darla Moore School of Business)*

View abstract

Selective Attention: Do Mutual Fund Incentives Affect Their Voting? (with Matthew Souther)

- **Conferences and Seminars:** Financial Management Association (2025), Southern Finance Association (2025), Global Finance Conference (2025)
- **Award:** *First Year Paper Award (Darla Moore School of Business)*

View abstract

Managerial Tax Attention and Corporate Tax Outcomes (with Jason DeBacker)

- **Conferences and Seminars:** 36th Annual Conference on Financial Economics and Accounting (CFEA 2026 scheduled), 119th Annual Conference on Taxation (2026 scheduled)

View abstract

The Paycheck Protection Program (PPP) from the Small Business Perspective: Did the PPP Help Alleviate Financial and Economic Constraints? (with Allen N. Berger, Paul G. Freed, Zheyu Qi, Jonathan A. Scott, and Siwen Zhang)

- **Revise & Resubmit:** *Journal of Banking & Finance*
- **Conferences and Seminars:** Southern Finance Association (2022)*, Financial Management Association (2022)*, Temple University*, University of South Carolina*

View abstract

WORK IN PROGRESS

Corporate Risk Saliency

Who Submits Shareholder Proposals and Why? (with Choonsik Lee and Matthew Souther)

Who Do You Trust?: Evidence from Mutual Fund Managers' Allocation Decisions (with Omrane Guedhami and Sadok El Ghoul)

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Empirical Corporate Finance, Corporate Governance, AI in Natural Language Processing (NLP), Machine Learning in Finance, Shareholder Voting

RESEARCH AND TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Research Assistant

Prof. Matthew Souther, University of South Carolina	*2023–Present*
Prof. Gregory R. Niehaus, University of South Carolina	*2022*
Prof. Chen Haiqiang, Xiamen University	*2019*

Instructor/Teaching Assistant

Corporate Finance, Instructor of Record, University of South Carolina	*Spring 2026 scheduled*
AI Bootcamp for PhD Students, Instructor, University of South Carolina	*Fall 2026*
Corporate Finance, Instructor of Record, University of South Carolina (Eval. 4.5/5.0)	*Fall 2025*
Investment Analysis and Portfolio Management, University of South Carolina	*2023, 2024*
Financial Statement Analysis, University of South Carolina	*2022*
Financial Economics, Xiamen University	*2019*
Quantitative Methods in Finance, University of Cape Coast	*2017*
Financial Management, University of Cape Coast	*2017*

CORPORATE EXPERIENCE

Internship, National Investment Bank, Kumasi, Ghana	*2016*
Internship, CSIR-Building and Road Research Institute, Kumasi, Ghana	*2015*

SCHOLARSHIPS AND AWARDS

Doctoral Fellows Award for Outstanding Academic & Research Performance	*2026, 2025*
University of South Carolina, Graduate School Travel Grant	*2025*
Best Second Year Paper Award, University of South Carolina	*2024*
First Year Paper Award, University of South Carolina	*2023*
Business Administration Scholarship, University of South Carolina	*2022, 2023, 2024*
Excellent International Student Award, Xiamen University	*2020*

Chinese Government Scholarship, Xiamen University	*2018*
Scholarship for First Class Students, ICA, Ghana	*2017*
Dean's Awards for High Academic Performance, University of Cape Coast	*2015, 2016, 2017*

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

(*by co-author)

36th Annual Conference on Financial Economics and Accounting (CFEA)		*(2026 scheduled)*
ABFR Doctoral Research Symposium		*(2026 scheduled)*
3rd Annual Boca Finance and Real Estate Conference		*(2026 scheduled)*
119th Annual Conference on Taxation*		*(2026 scheduled)*
3rd AI in Finance Conference		*2026*
Financial Management Association(FMA) Consortium		*2026*
RCF-ECGI Corporate Finance and Governance Conference		*2026*
Georgia State – *Management Science* AI & FinTech Conference		*2025*
Financial Management Association(FMA) Vancouver, Canada	×2 Papers	*2025*
Southern Finance Association(SFA) Conference Florida, USA	×2 Papers	*2025*
32nd Annual Global Finance Conference, Boston Massachusetts, USA		*2025*
FMA Conference, Atlanta, Georgia, USA*		*2022*

SERVICE

Reviewer, Journal of Behavioral and Experimental Finance	*2026*
Reviewer, Eastern Finance Association (EFA)	*2025*
Reviewer, Southern Finance Association (SFA)	*2025*
Conference Session Chair, FMA, SFA	*2025*
Discussant, FMA, SFA	*2025*
Brown Bag Coordinator, Darla Moore, Finance Department	*2024–Present*
Ph.D. Student Recruitment Assistant, Darla Moore, Finance Department	*2024*
Student Assistant, WISE-SOE international students, Xiamen University	*2019*
Co-Organizer and Speaker, WISE-SOE International Students Orientation	*2019*
Head of the Finance Committee, UCC Association of Business Students	*2016*

PROFESSIONAL MEMBERSHIPS

American Finance Association(AFA), Financial Management Association(FMA), Institute of Chartered Accountants, Ghana (ICAG) Level 2

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Machine Learning, Python, SAS, Stata, R, SLURM, LaTeX

INTERESTS AND HOBBIES

Teaching, soccer, hiking, country music

REFERENCES

Professor Matthew Souther
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Professor Gregory R. Niehaus
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Professor Jason DeBacker
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Professor Donghang Zhang
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RESEARCH ABSTRACTS

Changing the Subject: How Managerial Attention Reallocation Obscures Bad News (JMP)

I develop a measure of managerial attention reallocation using earnings-call transcripts from 2007 to 2023. Using BERTopic, I compare the distribution of topics in each firm's management presentation with its prior communication pattern. Unusual attention reallocation predicts negative abnormal returns, elevated crash risk over horizons of up to two years, persistently lower long-run returns, greater analyst forecast dispersion, and higher option-implied uncertainty. Attention reallocation also predicts subsequent adverse firm developments: a one-standard-deviation increase is associated with an 8.6% increase in bad-news 8-K filings over the following 90 days, as well as a greater incidence of ESG incidents. Markets and analysts do not fully incorporate the signal at the time of the call, suggesting that changes in managerial attention allocation contain information about future firm outcomes that is only partially reflected in prices. Back to paper

Can a Shareholder Focus Create Value for All Stakeholders? (with Matthew Souther)

We develop a novel machine-learning technique analyzing earnings call transcripts to measure whether a manager's focus is on shareholders or external stakeholders. We find that managers focusing on shareholders generate significantly higher stock returns in subsequent periods. However, these higher returns do not come to the detriment of other stakeholders; we find that shareholder-focused firms experience far fewer adverse environmental and social incidents, and those that do occur are less severe. Using natural disasters as an instrument for managerial focus and exploiting exogenous shifts in firm orientation induced by CEO transitions, we find that a shareholder focus causally reduces adverse E&S outcomes across all horizons examined. We conclude that a shareholder-focused strategy creates maximum value for both shareholders and stakeholders. Back to paper

Managerial Tax Attention and Corporate Tax Outcomes (with Jason DeBacker)

We construct a measure of corporate tax attention from the text of quarterly earnings calls for U.S. public firms over 2007 to 2023 using an unsupervised topic model. The measure captures within-firm deviations in tax attention from the firm's own historical same-quarter baseline. We find that elevated tax attention predicts lower cash effective tax rates over horizons of up to three years and generates positive announcement returns. A triple difference-in-differences design exploiting the Tax Cuts and Jobs Act of 2017 shows that firms with high pre-reform tax attention and high effective tax rates captured the largest post-reform reductions. Analysts revise earnings forecasts upward and realized earnings subsequently exceed their revised forecasts, consistent with partial incorporation of a signal that is available but costly to extract. Back to paper

Selective Attention: Do Mutual Fund Incentives Affect Their Voting? (with Matthew Souther)

In a sample of ballot items for which proxy advisor recommendations oppose management, we find that the likelihood of a mutual fund actively voting (deviating from proxy advisor recommendations) is significantly higher when the fund has larger monetary incentives tied to the portfolio holding. To address endogenous portfolio selection issues, we find the same result in a sample of passive index funds for which portfolio allocations are exogenous. Firms that are more commonly held by less incentivized funds have lower CEO delta and lower CEO turnover-performance sensitivity. Back to paper

The Paycheck Protection Program (PPP) from the Small Business Perspective: Did the PPP Help Alleviate Financial and Economic Constraints? (with Allen N. Berger, Paul G. Freed, Zheyu Qi, Jonathan A. Scott, and Siwen Zhang)

We employ two novel datasets to evaluate whether the Paycheck Protection Program (PPP) met short-term and longer-term goals. One dataset matches PPP with small business members of the National Federation of Business (NFIB) that report their financial constraints and their employees' economic constraints. We find more alleviation of both constraints for PPP recipients, consistent with short-term goals. We employ data on post- versus pre-crisis county employment, wages, and new businesses to test the longer-term goal of improved community crisis recoveries from the short-term constraint relief. We find to the contrary – worse longer-term recoveries in counties with more short-term constraint relief. Back to paper